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Carol Sudhalter Part II
(The Covid Interview)

The Covid-19 pandemic impacted the music and arts community particularly hard. Musicians who had previously been interviewed for the Fillius Jazz Archive graciously shared their experiences during this virtual shutdown period. The political and racial unrest occurring simultaneously was also addressed.

Carol was interviewed via Zoom on June 2, 2020, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and I'm happy to be with Carol Sudhalter today. You are the first person that I've met with under these circumstances. It would be interesting to gather some stories about how musicians are faring in these difficult times. Generally speaking, how are you doing?

CS: I am one of the lucky ones, Monk, I mean definitely. I'm doing just fine. It's not, you know, that different for me, and the ways in which it's different are very positive ways.

MR: Well tell me about that.

CS: Okay. So most of the time in my life I spend alone, just like I am now, in my house, preparing my lessons, cooking, practicing, and doing computer work, and that continues. Mostly every afternoon, well most of my income I should say comes from lessons: flute, sax, tenor sax, alto sax, piano, and clarinet lessons, house to house, which obviously is not an option now. I imagined at the beginning that most of my students would be running out of money and not be able to pay for online lessons because their jobs are closed, and that's not the case at all. I completely misjudged — this is an affluent community and they were very anxious to continue lessons. It also helps them because obviously the moms are very overwhelmed right now in a way they never expected. So I would say that out of all these, like I have between 25 and 30 students, all but three families have signed on, so that's a big load. I am teaching every day. Seven days, instead of the usual six. I try to keep the mornings for myself and the evenings for myself and that's working out well so I start at twelve, one, finish around six, and I try to give myself breaks in between lessons. Because it's very intense. You do need breaks. I really need to rest. It's a lot more intense than personal, in person lessons.

MR: Well before you were traveling to people's homes?

CS: Yeah. It was a good 25 miles at least every day, each way, so 50 miles a day, six days a week, and sometimes a little bit more than that.

MR: Have the students, have you noticed a difference in their motivation and how well they prepare for their lessons.

CS: Oh definitely, definitely. Well most of these kids play in bands in school, and the bands keep them practicing on their horns. The bands meet two or three times a week. So now they don't have that. Once in a while their school bands write to them and say, "Please record this piece, we have a click track" you know. So they do that. But mostly they're not practicing that much. They're not playing their horns that much. But the compensating factor is that I am finally able to give them a little bit of theory and give them what I want to give them. I'm using, with three students I'm using the Coker book, *Patterns for Jazz*, and they eat it right up. They like it. And with others I'm, you know, at least extending the scales up to the ninth and starting to teach them the arpeggios, at least on the one chord. Some more advanced students, I have one who is so advanced I don't even need to send him a copy of the book, I can just tell him what pattern it is and he just immediately, no matter how complex, he puts it into every key right away. He's very smart.

MR: I think you had mentioned this student during our first interview.

CS: Probably did. In some cases if they're really young, the parent tries to make time to sit with them, and that works a lot better because they're kind of shy, the little ones are kind of shy of the online lessons. They're a little scared.

MR: I noticed, I did a little bit of it to finish the Hamilton semester, and I also experienced that sort of intensity — I'm not sure what it comes from but it does sort of drain you.

CS: Well for me, part of it is, you know, I mean just the physical presence of the kids is so delightful. And they do these funny things, you know, they pull the wrinkles on my arm, or crazy stuff. And the parent brings me a cup of coffee. You know it really makes it a lot more anecdotal.

MR: You're taking the social element out of it.

CS: And it get to say hello to the dogs, all the dogs are my friends.

MR: Oh I hadn't thought of that. So it's not so much what it adds on it's what it takes away I guess.

CS: Well yeah I mean there's both you know. But that's I think what makes it so intense is that it's really — so now I have a system. I have a beautiful big folder, you know, with note cards for every kid. Every lesson I take notes, I know exactly where I am. I have my books all organized so I know which books to pull out. I don't normally have to do that. And that makes it a lot easier. So every day I pull out my huge notebook, it's a 3-ring. And then I pull out the files for the kids I'm going to teach that day and then I pull out those books and I look over my notes and I practice those instruments and then I'm all ready.

MR: Are you — I don't know what sort of platform you're using but can you play with them at the same time?

CS: I haven't found a platform where you can do that. I do, but I know there's always a delay. So I'm asking again, I'm asking the parents to try to have like a second device available so they can have something to play along with. In other words like I just discovered that on YouTube you can adjust the speed of the files.

MR: Right.

CS: Yeah, so they can go to a YouTube of a Jamey Aebersold, especially if it's somebody playing along with it, then it doesn't have to be me playing along, and they can slow that down if it's too fast, and use it as a study tool. But if they use it on FaceTime on the same device then I can't hear it.

MR: Right.

CS: It breaks it up.

MR: I had to have a student hip me to that thing about YouTube.

CS: Me too. A student just told me.

MR: We learn a lot from our students these days.

CS: We sure do.

MR: About technology.

CS: As far as gigs, I don't do that many gigs compared to some people. I don't live off gigs. And I mean it's partly choice and partly the way things turned out. But I'm very happy to be just home practicing, and the one steady gig that's a paying gig that I have I'm continuing online, so if you don't mind I'll tell you about that.

MR: Yeah.

CS: You know it's Flushing Town Hall in Queens. It's a very nice, well run, prestigious, state-of-the-art organization that presents concerts all the time. And I run the jam session once a month. It's a very well attended jam session. It's called the Louis Armstrong Legacy Flushing Town Hall Jazz Jam Session. A monthly jazz jam. Because it's funded by the Louis Armstrong Educational Foundation. And well it's so popular. You know I've been doing it for maybe four or five years and it's growing and growing, and the audience is super supportive and we get all this incredible variety of players you know, all levels. And a lot of good kids too you know. And so we decided to try and put that online and the only way we could do it was that it was not any longer a jam session but people record a piece at home, not a professional, not like a CD or something, but just record a piece either alone or with a track or with a partner. And then send it in to the engineer and he strings them up. And if somebody wants to play live they can but the quality isn't as good and it tends to freeze. So sending in works really well. And I'm still the moderator, and I still do all the credits and acknowledgements and introductions. And

the house band, as usual we play tunes associated with Louis Armstrong. So we still have all our house band members. And now the advantage is this: we get participants from all over the world, which you cannot do at a live jam. So last month we had New Zealand, Australia, Italy, and Germany. And the month before that we had Colorado, Italy, and a few other places, I can't remember.

MR: Are people able to chime in with comments?

CS: They do, yeah. I mean we try to have as many people as possible present. It's a little late for Italy, you know it's the middle of the night for them. But sometimes they do as well. So you can see on the screen, the participants are allowed to be on the screen in those little boxes. And they don't comment during the music. They can write little notes on the chat but — at the beginning we had comments during the music and it really became a little chaotic so we mute them now. But everyone has a chance to say hello at the beginning, like around 7:30, say a greeting, whatever they want to say. And at the end we also open up the mics for the audience or anyone that wants to say a nice hello. And we are getting our usual, a lot of members of our usual audience, many are senior citizens, but they are still able to get on either by phone or by Zoom. It's wonderful.

MR: Well congratulations. I'm amazed that people, the ingenuity that is happening, and I'm starting to wonder if when — we're going to assume that someday we're going to be back to normal, if things will return to where they were, or, in your case you're talking about this has been a positive thing, might you end up doing both a live jam and an online jam.

CS: It depends I guess on the budget, but that would be great. I would love to. We need more time every month. We'd never have enough time for all the players. I mean it's always a stress for me to try to fit everyone in on the evening. I try to call them up one at a time rather than two or three at a time you know, and give them a chance — in the live session.

MR: I'm not sure what you mean, calling them up.

CS: Okay so I mean when they come in and sign the sign-up list in the live jam, there might be 32 players and we only have short of three hours. So some jam sessions call up two or three players at a time to play with the house band. But I try to call them up one by one unless they're a set group. You know what I mean?

MR: Right.

CS: Okay. So it takes some time and we usually can just barely fit everyone in. At the end we usually have a big jam number, like a blues or something, where everybody gets up and sings or plays, and it's really sweet. I thought that up. I'm trying to think if there's a way to do that online you know, have everybody do one chorus of the blues and pass it from

one to the other, but I'm not sure if everybody could stay in the same key that way and stuff. Maybe. I'm working on it.

MR: Yeah. I think the things you see with orchestras playing together, I believe they must have some really high tech things going on there.

CS: Yeah. There's stuff you can buy. But we did a good one at the last jam. I did, on baritone sax I did "I'll Walk Alone." And you know Joe Tranchina, he's our house pianist, and he made me a track, he sent it to me, I played along with it on this tune. Then he sent it to the drummer and the bass player and they played a track. And then Joe did a beautiful mix. He lined them up, this took him a few hours. And you can hear it, you know, if you go on that recording of the last jam. It came out so sweet, really, really warm. It breathed. You know? A lot of the stuff online doesn't breathe but it breathed.

MR: Ah. That's a good way to put it.

CS: Yeah.

MR: Are there things that you had to stop doing — maybe seeking out gigs or something that took a lot of effort and time, that you really don't miss now and might not return to it?

CS: Yeah. In music though, not in life in general you mean?

MR: I think either.

CS: God I mean it's so different. I have some strange habits that I've set up in my schedule. For instance, to get to Long Island without traffic to teach, I go like an hour or two early and then I just kill time, either just sitting in the car doing email or shopping, just walking around in stores. I don't think I'll probably go back to that. I mean it's like little things like that. Oh I don't know, I'm not that interested in like restaurants and coffee shops and stuff anymore. I really like cooking. I don't know, musically I'd have to think about that, but gigs are good. I just don't miss them in the same way as some people do. It's so life or death now. It just doesn't seem like a relevant question. I mean it's — the health question is such a matter of life or death. It's like, I don't know. I mean it's like I just put everything aside. I don't —

MR: I think I know what you mean.

CS: Like it's an emergency.

MR: Yes. When the cancellations for me started to come in, you sort of got in this mode, "Oh there's another one, there's another one." And pretty soon there were no gigs in the foreseeable future. And it was easy to be angry and depressed about it, until you put it in a context, as you're suggesting, that yeah it's bad but relative to other things it's not that huge an issue.

CS: Right. I mean it's like a world-wide hurricane except there's no real end in sight, we don't know if there's going to be a second wave or a second peak in this wave, and you can die from it and I'm in that age, I could die too. But, that being said, it's easy for me to

say because I have a job. So I'm not experiencing that frustration, and on the contrary I like having a chance to be home and rest and not have to drive all that time.

MR: Did you feel responsible for anyone else? For instance, your house band with the jam session, when it became obvious that this wasn't going to be able to — did you feel responsible for those other musicians and trying to find a way for them to continue?

CS: Yeah. And I keep after them, trying to explain, you know like normally at the beginning of the session actually we only do two tunes as a house band before bringing up the rest of the audience participants. And I told them, everybody should do a tune. I told Scott, you know Scott, the drummer, Scott Neumann, I said, "Scott, you do a tune too, you can just play it on drums or use a track." He decided to sing. I told the whole band to think up tunes associated with Louis Armstrong so that we could keep our status as a band and be participants in the special way. We did put that quartet tune together but that's a lot of work for whoever mixes it. But yeah, I do feel responsible and I'm trying as much as I can. But I mean certainly teaching I could do what we're doing with the jam. I could get students from all over the world by online. You know, as you go you find out which instruments work best and which platforms work best. And I could teach somebody in any country by this way, and I think I was shy of that before.

MR: Yes I had not done any of it myself. It'll be curious to see if when you're able to go back and make house calls so to speak, if any of the parents will say, "You know let's stick with the online." That wouldn't be for you.

CS: That would be very interesting. I mean of course, I mean you've gotten into it a bit now, right?

MR: Just the semester at Hamilton, so I had about five weeks of it.

CS: I don't know, you probably don't have the kids that haven't quite gotten it together to set up the reed before you get on, or they go and spend ten minutes looking for their music. Then you can tear your hair out. Or they're out for a bike ride and the mom forgot to tell them.

MR: And you get to hear them going, "Come on inside now."

CS: Yeah and they apologize and some offer to pay me and all that if they messed up the schedule. But that's real frustrating. But I understand it. You know they've got a lot on their plates. One kid the other night, he manipulated me, and he told me that there was an emotional problem with a sibling and, "We just don't know what to do about it." His parents weren't even home. There was no "we."

MR: There's always a way to manipulate the system. This is a fairly deep question. I wonder if you have an opinion about the government response to this pandemic either from the local or state —

CS: Absolutely. Absolutely yes. I mean if you compare all the countries in the world, you know the dictatorial types, like our president and Bolsanaro and Putin. You know they're the ones that are having the worst pandemic experiences. We don't have it together. All these programs that were set up to prepare for a pandemic were cut out of the budget systematically over the years. Even the governor, as good a job as he's doing in some ways, had cut out also, funding to hospitals for Medicaid, had cut out many, many things over these past few years: extra beds, extra equipment, ventilators, had been cut. So when you go back and see that, we could have been in a much better situation than we are, and then from day to day it becomes crazier of course. So it makes a lot of difference in people's health, yeah. I'm glad people are protesting. It's about time. We'll see where it goes. Minorities are getting the rough end of the pandemic, definitely, I agree. And we need severe, serious change in the administration and that will affect the pandemic and it will affect jobs and whether people can pay the rent.

MR: Have you lost any friends through the pandemic?

CS: No? Oh lost, you mean lost, oh. I did. I lost one friend from my twelve-step group, yeah. He was a healthcare worker and I very much liked him and he was a huge contributor to the program. So yeah, he died, very early on, in March.

MR: There was a period of about seven days where it seemed like the musicians were being targeted almost. We lost Bucky Pizzarelli then Mike Longo and Ellis Marsalis and it was very sad of course.

CS: Yeah. Very sad. Very, very sad. And there's one author who is on FaceBook who keeps writing about the Broadway people that have died that he knew of, quite a few.

MR: Yeah. Do you think — I'm going to say your lifestyle, figuring out how to make a living in music sort of improvising along the way, has helped you figure out this next, this current situation?

CS: You know I think what's helped me is I have this kind of a cautious side to me, financially I've always been aware of my age and that I could become sick at any moment and wouldn't be able to work. All you have to do is fall down once and you can't drive to your lessons. And so I've always made sure to stick some money in the bank and not get caught, and try to make a mental list of what I could sell if I needed to, and that kind of thing. Also, because of global warming and knowing you can be hit by any kind of a storm of any kind you know, any kind of a pollution thing or a meltdown, there's so much in this world that you know people tend to block out I guess but I listen and I try to learn and I think about that, all the what ifs. And so I have that side. And my father had it. I got it from him. He had it to an extreme. He always like worried and bit his nails and thought about — he put aside money for my college since I was like born or before that, and stuff like that. I don't go as far as that but I mean I try not to worry about

I try to concretely keep track of that financially. So that's what I think has helped me over the years, and now especially.

MR: Well it's nice to hear — you are fairly upbeat, and I hope other musicians can echo some of your sentiments. I know people who, some of my friends who depend totally on gigs and they have nothing. They've entered the unemployment realm and they seem to be doing okay. I'm sure they wish they hadn't had to do that.

CS: Absolutely. I mean yeah. People are definitely suffering. Musicians are suffering hardest, composers, actors, oh my God. I mean that's yeah. There needs to be much more support programs and grants. There's a good start but it's not enough.

MR: Right. Well Carol I appreciate connecting with you again.

CS: It's great to see you.

MR: Really. You know in my basement, it's covered with posters of things I've been involved with and we have your poster in a prominent position, when you came to Hamilton.

CS: Thank you.

MR: Yeah.

CS: I have to say that during this time a new book came out by Royal Stokes, the author, and I have a pretty prominent place in it. He's got several entries for me, not real short either, and pictures, a couple of pictures.

MR: Oh great. I'll look for it. What's the name of it?

CS: It's called *The Jazz Reader* I'll tell you in a sec. W. Royal Stokes, *The Essential Royal Stokes Jazz, Blues and Beyond Reader*.

MR: Okay. Now we have it on tape.

CS: Yeah.

MR: Okay.

CS: That's it. So I'm really pleased. And another guy, Peter Zimmerman, who lives upstate, he's got a new book in the works, he's just waiting for the publisher to decide what he's going to cut out. And I've got a chapter in there too. So I'm happy about that.

MR: Good. Well I wish you continued good luck. And I'll see you on the flip side.

CS: Yeah. I hope I will see you soon, you know, sooner or later.

MR: Very good.